

**NAME OF SCHOOL: MATER MISERICORDIAE SECONDARY SCHOOL,
RUMOMASI**

TERM: SECOND 2026/2027 ACADEMIC SESSION

WEEK: SEVEN

CLASS: SS1

SUBJECT: Government

TOPIC: Separation of Powers

Introduction

- Separation of powers is the doctrine (formulated by Baron de Montesquieu) that the legislative, executive and judicial functions of government should be exercised by separate and independent organs, so that power is not concentrated in one hand.

The three organs

- **Legislature** — makes laws, approves the budget, ratifies treaties and checks the executive (in Nigeria, the National Assembly).
- **Executive** — implements laws, conducts foreign policy and runs the daily affairs of the state (the President and the cabinet).
- **Judiciary** — interprets the law, settles disputes and reviews the constitutionality of actions (the courts, from the Supreme Court down).

Checks and balances

- The legislature can override a veto, impeach, confirm appointees and refuse budgets; the executive can veto bills and propose laws; the judiciary can declare acts null and void. These mutual checks prevent the abuse of power and make each organ accountable.

Limitations

- Neither complete separation nor absolute independence is possible in practice — the President signs bills (a legislative act) and the Senate confirms appointments (an executive role); party discipline and the fusion of powers in the parliamentary system weaken the separation.

CLASS EVALUATION

1. Explain separation of powers.
2. State the function of each organ of government.
3. Give two checks the legislature has over the executive.
4. Why is absolute separation of powers impossible?

**NAME OF SCHOOL: MATER MISERICORDIAE SECONDARY SCHOOL,
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TERM: SECOND 2026/2027 ACADEMIC SESSION

WEEK: EIGHT

CLASS: SS1

SUBJECT: Government

TOPIC: Rule of Law

Introduction

- The rule of law is the supremacy of law over every person and authority — government by law and not by men. Its currency in modern governance owes much to A.V. Dicey.

Dicey's principles

- **Supremacy of the law** — the law rules all; no one is punished except for a breach of the law.
- **Equality before the law** — all persons, officials and private citizens alike, are subject to the same law and the same courts.
- **Fundamental rights** — the courts protect the rights of individuals (fair hearing, presumption of innocence).

Safeguards and practice

- An independent judiciary; a constitution that limits state power; free press and civil society; an efficient police and courts; public enlightenment. In practice the rule of law is threatened by corruption, the delay of justice, poverty (which limits access to lawyers), ignorance, immunity clauses and executive lawlessness.

CLASS EVALUATION

1. Define the rule of law.
2. State the three principles of the rule of law.
3. What safeguards protect the rule of law in a democracy?
4. Mention two obstacles to the rule of law in Nigeria.

**NAME OF SCHOOL: MATER MISERICORDIAE SECONDARY SCHOOL,
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TERM: SECOND 2026/2027 ACADEMIC SESSION

WEEK: NINE

CLASS: SS1

SUBJECT: Government

TOPIC: Democracy

Introduction

- Democracy is government of the people, by the people and for the people (Abraham Lincoln). It is a system in which the people choose their rulers through free and fair elections.

Types of democracy

- **Direct democracy** — all citizens vote on every issue (ancient Athens; the referendum and plebiscite are modern survivals).
- **Indirect (representative) democracy** — citizens elect representatives who decide on their behalf (Nigeria, USA, UK).
- Other forms: liberal (with constitution, rights and free press), social (with welfare and equity), and socialist (the party/state leads).

Conditions for democracy

- An informed citizenry; free and fair elections and an independent electoral commission (INEC); a free press; an independent judiciary; viable political parties; the rule of law; a strong civil society; and political tolerance.

CLASS EVALUATION

1. Define democracy.
2. Differentiate between direct and representative democracy.
3. State four conditions for the practice of democracy.
4. Why is an independent judiciary necessary for democracy?

**NAME OF SCHOOL: MATER MISERICORDIAE SECONDARY SCHOOL,
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TERM: SECOND 2026/2027 ACADEMIC SESSION

WEEK: TEN

CLASS: SS1

SUBJECT: Government

TOPIC: Electoral Processes

Introduction

- An election is the process by which the people choose their representatives. The electoral process is the series of steps from voter registration to the declaration of results.

The stages

- 1. Creation of constituencies and delimitation of boundaries. 2. Voter registration and display of the register. 3. Party primaries and nomination of candidates. 4. Campaigns (regulated by law — no violence, hate speech or state resources). 5. Accreditation and voting (on election day, by secret ballot). 6. Counting and tallying. 7. Declaration of results and issuance of certificates of return. 8. Election petitions (to the tribunals and courts).

The electoral system

- The first-past-the-post (simple majority) system is used in Nigeria; the INEC conducts and supervises elections and registers parties and voters; the winner of a presidential election must win a majority and spread it across states.

Electoral malpractice

- Rigging, ballot-stuffing, thuggery, vote-buying, manipulation of results, the misuse of state resources and the intimidation of voters weaken democracy — the reasons for card readers and the electronic transmission of results.

CLASS EVALUATION

1. Define an election.
2. List the stages of the electoral process.
3. State the functions of INEC.
4. Mention four forms of electoral malpractice.

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TERM: SECOND 2026/2027 ACADEMIC SESSION

WEEK: ELEVEN

CLASS: SS1

SUBJECT: Government

TOPIC: Suffrage & The Franchise

Introduction

- Suffrage (the franchise) is the right to vote in elections. Universal adult suffrage means that all adult citizens, without discrimination, may vote.

Evolution of the franchise in Nigeria

- The colonial era restricted the franchise (limited to the educated elite in the early regional elections — the 1923 Clifford Constitution); the 1951 Macpherson Constitution extended it; universal adult suffrage came with the 1954 Lyttleton Constitution and the federal elections of 1959 — though women voted in the West before the North. The 1979 and 1999 Constitutions guarantee universal adult suffrage: every citizen 18 years and above has the right to register and vote.

Qualifications for voting in Nigeria

- A citizen of Nigeria; 18 years and above; registered as a voter; of sound mind; and a resident in the constituency (or registered in it). Disqualifications: dual citizenship in certain cases, unsound mind, and lawful imprisonment.

Importance and problems

- The franchise is the foundation of democracy: it makes the government answerable and legitimate. Problems: registration hitches, vote buying, apathy, violence and rigging — which is why civic education and voter enlightenment matter.

CLASS EVALUATION

1. Define suffrage.
2. What are the qualifications for voting in Nigeria?
3. Trace briefly the evolution of the franchise in Nigeria.
4. State two problems of the electoral process.

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TERM: SECOND 2026/2027 ACADEMIC SESSION

WEEK: TWELVE

CLASS: SS1

SUBJECT: Government

TOPIC: Political Parties & Pressure Groups

Introduction

- A political party is an organised group of citizens with a common programme, seeking to capture and control government through elections. A pressure group is an organised interest group that seeks to influence government policy without seeking power.

Functions of political parties

- They aggregate and articulate interests; nominate candidates; contest elections; form governments or oppositions; educate the electorate; and link the people to the government.

Party systems

- One-party (only one party is allowed); two-party (two dominant parties — USA, UK); multi-party (many parties contest — Nigeria). Nigeria has experimented with two-party (the NPN/UPN era) and multi-party systems (the current one).

Pressure groups

- Examples: trade unions (NLC), professional bodies (NBA, NMA), employers' associations (NACCIMA), students' unions, market women associations, and NGOs. Methods: lobbying, strikes, demonstrations, publicity and memoranda. They differ from parties because they do not seek to win elections or form a government.

CLASS EVALUATION

1. Define a political party.
2. State four functions of political parties.
3. Differentiate between a political party and a pressure group.
4. Name three pressure groups in Nigeria.